

HAITI: CIVIL UNREST

Summary of Secondary Data Analysis
13 March 2019



According to the IFRC approach for Emergency Needs Assessments, secondary data is either collected by others or consolidated from existing sources. Secondary data can be a mixture of pre-disaster information and post-disaster information.

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Summary of Secondary Data Analysis

The information presented here does not imply the expression of any opinion on the part of the International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies or National Societies.



SITUATION AND CRISIS PROFILE

Violent protests across Haiti have taken place since January 2019 as a result of a number of factors, including the increasingly high cost of living and accusations of the misuse of \$2 billion from an oil programme by the Haitian Government. This oil alliance is a fund created by Venezuela to support Haiti's development of oil production at low rates. Resources obtained from the programme are required to be used for projects that develop the country's infrastructure, economy, and social programs. Protests have led to business closures, leaving the population struggling to access essential goods and services, such as fuel, electricity, water, gas, food and more.

According to media reports, protesters have vandalized public and private property, used fire-arms, blocked roads and disrupted economic activity in country's major cities, leaving tourists trapped in hotels. Reports indicate that several people have been killed and many more injured in the protests.



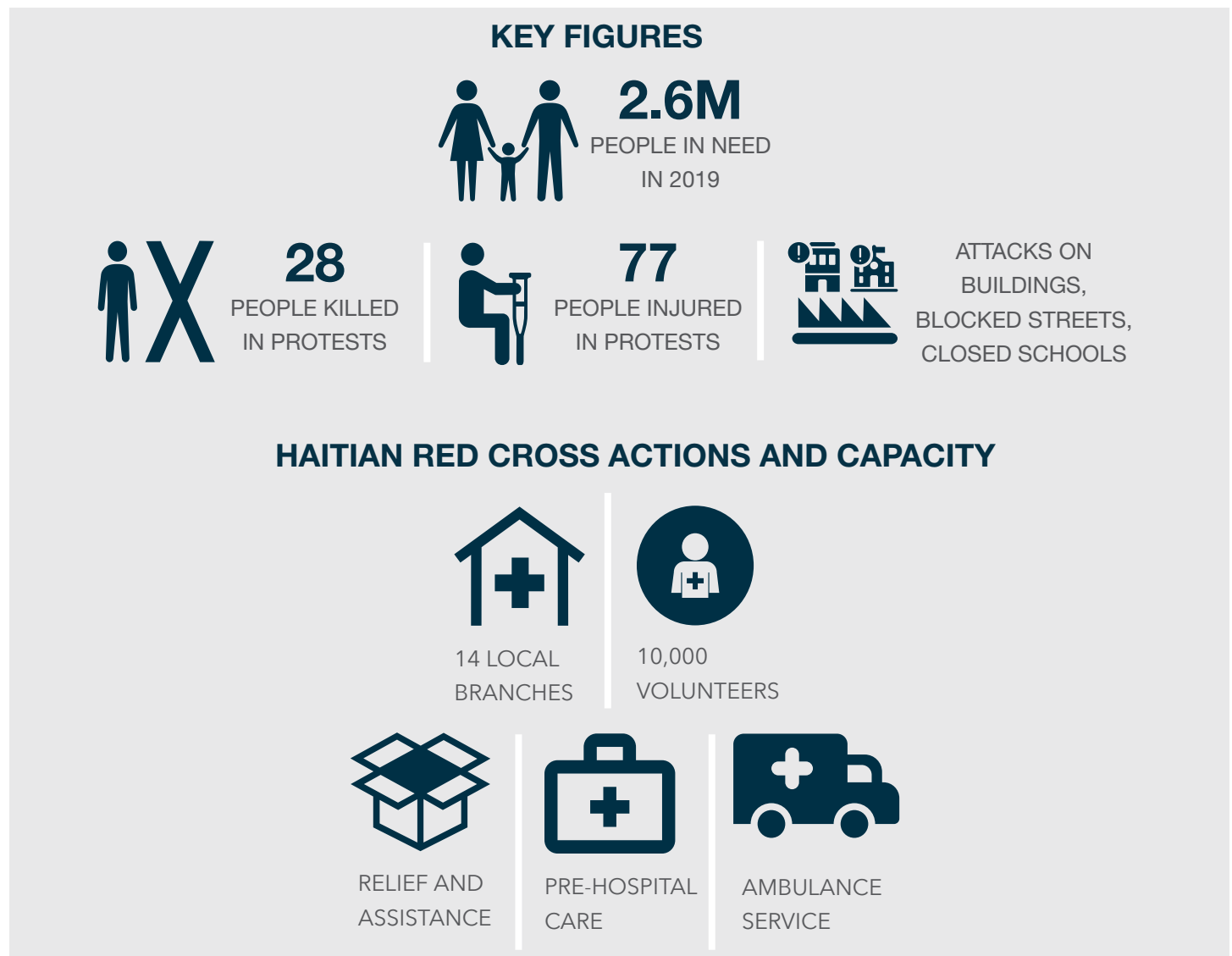
COUNTRY'S VULNERABILITY

According to the World Bank, 59 percent of the country's population lives below the poverty line (on less than \$2.41 per day) and almost one in four live in extreme poverty (less than \$1.23 a day). Less than 40 percent of Haitians have access to electricity. The country has a reported unemployment rate of 14 percent, but the real figure is believed to be higher. According to a report from the United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) in July 2018, 1.3 million Haitians depend on food assistance.

Besides persistent political instability, Haiti is still recovering from several major disasters in the last decade, including the devastating earthquake in 2010; a cholera epidemic that claimed near 8500 lives, according to the Haitian Ministry of Public Health and Population; and Hurricane Matthew, which wiped out 90 percent of buildings along the southern coast at an estimated cost of USD 1.9 billion in 2016.

Last year, Haiti suffered a period of severe drought and floods, and was struck by another earthquake, which left 17 people dead, over 350 injured, over 2000 houses destroyed and 16000 damaged; all as the country continues to cope with continuing cholera, diphtheria and malaria epidemics, and a migration crisis which has displaced Haitians to Dominican Republic or and countries in the Latin American and Caribbean region. According to Human Rights Watch, at least 250000 Dominicans of Haitian descent and Haitian migrants working in the Dominican Republic re-entered Haiti between June 2015 and March 2018, after deportations began in the Dominican Republic.

The analysis of Humanitarian Needs Overview (HNO) identified that approximately 2.6 million people in Haiti need humanitarian assistance in 2019. The humanitarian community is targeting 1.3 million vulnerable people.



GEOGRAPHIC SCOPE OF THE ANALYSIS

The data on the latest events in Haiti was collected from 5 February to 12 March from English and Spanish language mass media outlets, reports from Red Cross sources and other agencies.



KEY EVENTS



July 2018: Widespread protests and civil unrest in response to the Government's announcement that it would eliminate fuel subsidies, allowing prices to increase up to 50 percent.



October – November 2018: Widespread protests leave at least 12 people dead and more than 50 people hurt and many arrests.



February 5, 2019: Declaration by the Government of a state of economic emergency.



February 7: Large-scale protests and demonstrations are held in major cities across the country. Two people reported killed.



February 9: Armed gangs joining the protests. One person killed.



February 12 – 15: Protests continue and security situation in Port-au-Prince and major cities is delicate.



February 12: 78 detainees escape from a prison in Aquin, a town in Southern Haiti.



February 14: Haitian President addressed to the country.



February 15: Countries including the United States, Canada and France issue warnings to citizens not to travel to Haiti as protests continue.



February 17: At least 26 people killed during the protests and 77 people injured.



February 28: Airlines including Air Canada and Jet Blue announce cuts to the number of flights to Haiti.



RISKS



Protesters have blocked roads, making passage through Port-au-Prince difficult, including for emergency responders.



The country's poorest population, who live on \$2 a day, will experience increasing difficulties buying goods as the prices of food and fuel continue to rise.



Approximately 568,000 people live in areas at high risk of being affected by natural disasters. Haiti is among the most vulnerable countries in the world, according to the [2019 INFORM report](#).



More than 333,000 people are living in areas still affected by cholera.



The current economic crisis is likely to increase the risk of violence, sexual exploitation, family separation and child domestic work.



The current crisis has generated a considerable illegal migration which has expanded to several Caribbean Islands, United States, Central America and South America.



Power outages are raising the risk that medical centers lose the ability to effectively store vaccines.

AGGRAVATING FACTORS

1

Severe drought has resulted in a significant decline in agricultural production and average household income

2

El Niño in 2019 will likely increase the persistence of drought in parts of the country

3

Hurricane season begins in June

4

Approximately 2.6 million Haitians are expected to be food insecure during the lean season (March – June 2019)

5

Haiti and the Dominican Republic are the only countries where cholera epidemics are still prevalent



ECONOMIC IMPACT

The current economic crisis is the result of a variety of factors, including the devaluation of local currency against the US dollar which has lost 25 percent of its value in 2018 accusations of misuse of \$2 billion by the government, and food and fuel price increases as a result of inflation of up to 30 percent for basic goods in the last 12 months. These economic hardships have led to nation-wide disturbances which have affected markets and severely impacted the income livelihoods of the population.

The country is losing investors' confidence, especially in the construction sector, according to finance analysis sources. The tourism sector has also declined, triggering the cancellation of February's Carnival celebrations (which generated \$5.8 billion in revenue in 2018).

Additionally, airlines including Air Canada and Jet Blue announced cuts to the number of flights to Haiti and travel booking websites including Expedia have reportedly blocked visitors from booking trips to the country. The damage to the image of Haiti's image as a tourist destination is putting future foreign infrastructure investment at risk.



SECURITY

The worsening security situation in Haiti is impacting all facets of life in the country. According to media reports, the national police force has lost control of much of the country as disturbances and road blockages become increasingly unpredictable. The departure of the UN peacekeeping mission (MINUSTAH) in 2017 has exacerbated the current situation.

CRISIS FORECAST

The country has experienced relative calm in recent weeks but the risk of renewed protests remains.

If protests reignite, access to basic services and goods will continue to diminish.

The impending arrival of El Niño, drought, and hurricane season all need to be monitored.

INFORMATION GAPS

1

National Society actions in response to the current situation

2

Reliance of mass media sources

3

Government's damage evaluations and response actions

METHODOLOGY AND INFORMATION SOURCES

This is a comprehensive analysis of public secondary sources that focuses on Haiti.

The Information Management team within the Disaster and Crisis Department at the IFRC Regional Office for the Americas compiled recent documents for the secondary data analysis process. These documents were published through humanitarian organizations, news outlets, and others.

The secondary data analysis has been processed and extrapolated through the “Data Entry and Exploration Platform” (DEEP).

Sources reliability: Medium

Credibility: Medium

This document is a summary of the analysis and processing of documents from several sources. Contact im.americas@ifrc.org to obtain a copy of the complete document.

Contact im@ifrc.org or im.americas@ifrc.org to more information about IFRC Analytical Framework and secondary data processing through DEEP.